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Everyday Life in Lahore Cantonment under British Rule, 1849-1947

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Abstract
This article examines everyday life in Lahore Cantonment during colonial rule from the annexation of Punjab in 1849 to the end of British rule in 1947. Lahore Cantonment, first developed around Mian Mir, became a site where European officers, Indian soldiers, civilian labourers, traders, servants, women, and medical authorities encountered one another under unequal conditions. Barrack routine bazaar licensing, disease control, moral regulation, transport, and leisure all reveal how British rule depended on the management of space and conduct. It argues that the cantonment was not merely a military station but a regulated colonial environment in which law, spatial planning, discipline, sanitation, labour control, and racial hierarchy shaped ordinary experience. By bringing together the Military Cantonments Act of 1864, the Cantonments Acts of 1889 and 1924, district gazetteers, sanitary reports, anti-malarial investigations, and secondary scholarship on colonial Punjab and military urbanism, the article shifts attention from campaigns, recruitment, and high politics to the daily practices through which empire was reproduced. The study contributes to the social history of British Punjab by bringing to light how the colonial order was experienced in routine acts of living, working, moving, cleaning, trading, policing, and socializing within a military township.

Keywords: Lahore Cantonment; British Punjab; Colonial Order; Everyday Life; Military History; Social Control; Colonial Urbanism.

Introduction

In 1849, the British East India Company annexed Punjab, transforming the region's political, military, and social landscape. The British seized authority in the Sikh Kingdom after the Second Anglo-Sikh War and set up new institutions and military formations to secure British control. The region's strategic location and agricultural significance soon made it one of the most important provinces of British India. The province increasingly came into prominence after the mutiny of 1857, when the British used Punjabi recruits extensively for the Indian Army. In this broader context, cantonments played an important role in organising and sustaining colonial power (Tan, 2005). In this study, two essential questions are tackled. First, what impact did British military rule have on the everyday life of the Lahore Cantonment? Second, how did the regulations of social relations and urban spaces help maintain colonial order? The study puts questions at the centre of interest, going beyond institutional histories of the army and providing a focus on the practical functioning of empire in the lives of people.

The paper argues that Lahore Cantonment became a small version of British Colonial rule in Punjab. It was not just a station for the military, but an essentially controlled space where discipline, surveillance, and racial separation shaped daily life, as did the law (Glover, 2008).

Colonial management applied its structures and devices, its organisations of barracks and its policing of economic life, as well as its rules on health and morality and its control of travel and leisure, to routinize common activities and to make them act as tools of imperial control. The cantonment thus occupied more than just a military precinct, but also a significant center of British power and presence. The Military Cantonments Act 1864 and the Cantonments Acts 1889 and 1924 gave powers to officials to control sanitation, housing, trade, movement and civilian activity in the military settlements. In this way, the cantonment became significant in establishing and maintaining colonial order.

Lahore (Mian Mir) Cantonment, established in 1850, emerged as one of the largest and most important military stations in northern India. Historians of colonial Punjab have examined various aspects of British rule in the province, particularly its administrative, economic, and social transformations under imperial governance (Talbot, 1988). Further the themes of military recruitment patterns, organisation structures within the army, idea of martial races and patronage have also been addressed (Omissi, 1994; Tan, 2005). They have immensely contributed to the knowledge of the relationship between the army and colonial rule in Punjab. However, these significant works have paid limited attention to the everyday lives of people who lived and worked in and around cantonments. The experiences of soldiers within barracks, the role of civilian labour and contractors, the regulation of markets and public health, the management of gender and sexuality, and the interactions between military personnel and local populations have received limited scholarly attention. By looking at these dimensions, an understanding of colonial power as it worked outside official institutions and military policies can be enhanced.

Methodologically, this study uses a qualitative historical approach based on primary and secondary sources. The primary materials consist of the Cantonment Acts, Punjab Gazetteers, military reports, records of Lahore Municipality, memoirs, and contemporary newspapers. These sources provide valuable evidence on the legal structures and social realities of the cantonment system that enable us to get a glimpse of the law and the social system.

Social Hierarchies and Racial Order in Lahore Cantonment

Lahore Cantonment was not just a military place; it was a socially organised colonial space, with a person's position in everyday life determined by his or her race, rank and occupation. British officials set up a pecking order, favouring Europeans, and at the same time relying on Indian soldiers and those working in the civilian sector to help keep colonial society going. These disparities were part of the imperial ideology of supremacy, leadership, and racial difference.

European officers occupied the highest position within the cantonment’s social hierarchy. They lived in spacious bungalows surrounded by gardens and open spaces, enjoyed access to exclusive clubs and recreational facilities, and exercised authority over both military and civilian populations. They were not just soldiers but privileged people, and this privilege was due to their colonial ideology. Keeping the vision of difference between the rulers and the ruled alive was vital to the British Indian Army, part of an effort to ensure imperial authority and discipline (Peers, 1995). The separation of European officers from the indigenous population therefore became an essential feature of colonial governance.

The situation of Indian soldiers was more complicated. Since the Independence Movement of 1857, the policies of the British recruitment had been tilted highly towards Punjab. The colonial authorities portrayed the Sikhs, Jats, Rajputs, and Pathans as "martial races" who were "natural", that is, not subject to British training but rather fit for military duties (Rand & Wagner, 2012; Soherwordi, 2010). This theory legitimised selective recruitment practices, as well as rehashing stereotypes about loyalty and manliness that affect race. Tan Tai Yong sees the recruitment of troops as an event that changed Punjab into a "garrison state," where the military had a tremendous influence on society and governance (Tan, 2005). Working in the army provided regular income

and social prestige, and sometimes access to land grants, making it an attractive career choice for many Punjabi families.

However, the recruitment of Punjabis into the colonial army did not mean that they got equality. Indian soldiers were still subject to their European counterparts, though it was important for the empire's defence. There was limited promotion for Indian soldiers, and advancement was still in the hands of the British. Trust in indigenous troops was therefore conditional (Omissi, 1994). In addition to their colonial defence by Indian soldiers, the British used to uphold racial barriers which tried to stop challenges to colonial rule. The relationship between the British officer and the Indian sepoy therefore reflected one of the central contradictions of empire: dependence combined with exclusion.

Under these groups were civilian workers who provided the means to life in the cantonment. Domestic servants, sweepers, water carriers, cooks, artisans, and market traders supplied much-needed services to military homes and to the military institutions. Essential to the good order of the cantonment, they came at the bottom of the colonial pyramid. The economic power imbalance in colonial society is also evident in the distribution of the records. The fact that they are underrepresented among the records is proof of the economic difference in colonial society. The Cantonment thus had to rely on a level of military discipline, and also on local population contributions, which were largely unrecognised.

British authorities deliberately organised cantonments into distinct zones. European officers lived in bungalow areas with wide roads, extensive open spaces and facilities for sanitation. Indian soldiers were accommodated in separate barracks, which were designed to ensure discipline and surveillance. Bazaars, labour settlements and servant quarters were inhabited by the civil body outside the elite residential spaces. These were divided into European neighbourhoods, Indian lines and bazaars, servants' quarters and military barracks. It signified the imbalance of power in colonial society (Glover, 2008; King, 1976).

Anthony King's colonial urbanism approach suggests that the colonial planning of settlement processes fixated social differences through the physical drawing of a space of power. This was seen in the manifestation of Lahore Cantonment. This segregation was not simply informal, but formalized by colonial laws and measures, including the Military Cantonments Act of 1864, which gave authorities control over spaces, disease, zoning, spatial control, and “nuisances,” both Europeans and indigenous people (Government of India, 1864). The Cantonments Act 1889, which left no ambiguity about the administrative control, further segregated residential patterns by giving Cantonment Boards authority to control residences, trade, building permissions and health measures (Government of India, 1889). Subsequently, these were combined and enhanced through the Cantonments Act of 1924, which gave the military a tight grip over civilian settlements in and around cantonments, while empowering them with municipal type administration (Government of India, 1924).

These legal documents paved the way for systematic regulation of movement of both Europeans and Indians and for physiologically separating European quarters, Indian lines, bazaars, servant quarters and labour settlement. This system of governing colonial rule was based on keeping people of different races/cultures apart. Building, roads and public spaces thus became part of the administrative apparatus which normalised colonial control, and the order of everyday social hierarchy.

Thus, an examination of Lahore Cantonment does not paint the image of neutral military settlements. Instead, they served as places where colonial ideas were manifested as lived experiences. Both privileges and access to work, authority, and privilege were organised by social hierarchy, and interactions between social communities were organized by space. Through these mechanisms, colonial power became embedded within the ordinary routines of everyday life, into colonial practices of everyday life (Jacob, 1994). The organisation of Lahore Cantonment was

therefore central to the maintenance of British rule in Punjab, which means that maintaining the rule and empire also involved a regulation of society and space.

Discipline, Surveillance and Everyday Life

The conversion of Lahore Cantonment into a highly regulated colonial space was inextricably tied to the British anxieties of security, control and governance in post 1857 India. Colonial authorities started suspecting Indian soldiers of being unreliable after the Indian rebellion in 1857, planning military administration and strengthening the institutional control in Cantonments. This change went beyond military tactics, transforming the arrangement of daily life, movement, time and conduct were controlled and formalized through rules and informal 'police' systems. Cantonments, then, became places of controlled administrative procedures, spatial design, and disciplinary operations that created uniformity and predictability. In this context, Lahore Cantonment was a tightly regulated military environment where disciplinary rule and routine were enforced not only by law and punishment, but also by the one-by-one elimination of everyday habits and the disciplining of time.

Discipline was one of the defining features of daily life within Lahore Cantonment. To British authorities, routine, supervision, and obedience were not just necessary for efficiency in military service; they were essential for the maintenance of colonial order. After the rebellion of 1857, worries about the reliability of native soldiers grew, as did official attempts to oversee soldiers' behavior with growing facility and through more intricate administrative structures (Omissi, 1994; Roy, 2013). The cantonment consequently became a space where time itself was subjected to military control.

The daily lives of soldiers were organised around fixed schedules, which determined most of their activities. The "subject programmes," such as roll calls, parade drill, inspections, meals, guard duty and training exercises, were carried out exactly as outlined, and the aim was to minimize idleness and foster conformity. The sanitary commissions have gathered evidence which proves that routine in the matter of work, rest and food played an essential part in the maintenance of discipline and health among the army forces (Ahmed, 2025). Routine was thus not simply administrative ease but a means for the creation of military subjects that were to be obedient.

Barrack design reinforced these disciplinary objectives. Accommodation was provided to assist in the supervision of activities and make sure that all military organizations were not in the same area. There were racial divisions within the colonial army, with European people occupying separate quarters from Indian regiments. The physical layout of cantonments, therefore, assisted the establishment of order and control, for soldiers were made visible and more readily available for military control (Home, 1997). The importance of surveillance was an indication of the importance of the concept of discipline, while it was important to observe continuously rather than to formally punish.

Military regulations extended beyond combat preparedness into the management of soldiers' personal conduct. Not only was military hardware subject to inspection, but cleanliness and order in living quarters were as well. Repeatedly, administrative reports associated discipline with controlling one's body, so that an organized soldier had also been expected to demonstrate ideals of hygiene, sobriety and self-control (Spiers, 1980). These expectations developed out of concerns of making sure the Empire was safe and also of the idea that disciplined army men weren't as susceptible to insubordination.

People not on the military hierarchy were subject to informal control as well. Civilian staff, camp followers and traders within the cantonment were expected to follow these rules regarding movement and public conduct in the cantonment. Markets and service areas were periodically inspected, and activities which were deemed to be interfering with the services received attention (Ahmed, 2025). The practice of discipline was thus not only a military practice but rather a general rule of governance that encompassed various aspects of cantonment life.

Sanitation, Leisure, and the Governance of Bodies

When the authority of the discipline was extended to the issues of health and recreation, it showed how wide its platform of colonial rule was in the cantonments of Lahore. With the early large number of deaths at the end of the 19th century amongst the European troops, official enquiries were conducted with regard to the sanitary conditions of military settlements throughout India. This investigation increasingly characterized health as more than the function of an administrative responsibility with a military necessity (Royal Commission on the Sanitary State of the Army in India, 1863).

The sanitary commissions' recommendations saw overcrowding and unhealthy conditions, such as inadequate ventilation, unsafe water supplies, and bad drainage, all go down the list of causes for the weakening of military effectiveness. The barracks were then modified to increase the flow of air and drainage, and to ensure proper disposal of waste and cleanliness. Such measures were indicative of the increasing emphasis on the importance of preventive medicine in colonial government (Royal Commission on the Sanitary State of the Army in India, 1863). Sanitary reform also, however, created new possibilities for the state in general to intervene in everyday life.

Legislative provisions enhanced these processes. The Military Cantonments Act of 1864 gave officials the power to take action about nuisances, to control sanitation and to take measures that would be good for public health (Government of India, 1864). Subsequent Acts extended the Cantonment Administration so that there was more control over inhabited places, markets, and place of common resort. This control was achieved with the help of concrete regulatory arrangements. For instance, the Cantonments Act, (1889) enabled cantonment authorities to supervise bazaars and issue licences, while also enabling them to control activities that were deemed inappropriate or unwholesome within the military limits (Government of India, 1889). The Cantonments Act of 1924 was one more step towards consolidating these powers as it enhanced the strength of Cantonment Boards, making sanitation, building activities, roads, markets, provision of water and drainage and public health under systematic administrative controls. In practice, this allowed the authorities to demand licenses from shopkeepers, to inspect or rearrange bazaars, to modify or change congested and unsanitary areas for military hygiene and public order (Nathan et al., 1910). Additionally, residential areas like Indian lines, servant quarters, labour settlements, and bazaar areas were also controlled through building rules, sanitation checkups, and movement control in the proximity of military areas (Qureshi, 1997). In this way, the subsequent cantonment regulations regulated the markets, the residential quarters, and the public spaces as zones of close supervision where the daily life of civilians was still dominated by military-administrative measures.

Medical inquiry carried out in Mian Mir Cantonment further vividly depicts this feature. In the early twentieth century anti-malarial campaigns explored drainage and stagnant water, bazaar conditions, and homes of soldiers and their dependents (Nathan et al., 1910). These questions reveal the colonial preoccupations often extending beyond disease matters into attempts to regulate the wider ways of social living. Administrative control over the military and civilian population was thus strengthened by environmental control.

Official interest was also taken in leisure. Military authorities saw a potential to affect morale, health, and discipline through soldiers' behavior in their off-duty timings. Health promoting activities such as recreational facilities, libraries, gymnasia and organised sports were encouraged as alternative behaviours to those deemed as harmful to military efficiency (Royal Commission on the Sanitary State of the Army in India, 1863). Events, such as the initiation of rules on how soldiers spent their leisure time, aimed to promote a way of life that was marked by self-regulation.

At the same time, excessive drinking, gambling and other customs that were believed to cause disorder were also of concern. The pressure to control leisure was an extension of other

assumptions that the stability of the empire was not just a matter of military readiness, but also a matter of the moral character of those who had to defend it, for leisure created conditions that could easily lead to rebellion and unrest. The regulation of recreation was enforced through military discipline rules, cantonment standing orders, and conduct regulations that restricted gambling, drinking, and unsupervised movement, while promoting supervised sports, drills, and controlled club activities (Omissi, 1994; Roy, 2013). However, these interventions should not be viewed as infallible. However, the daily life of the cantonments often made it difficult for officials to regulate their activities. Enforcement of discipline was inhibited by informal relations amongst bazaars' inhabitants, by cyclic trading between soldiers and civilians, and by the employment of tactics of adaptive coping on the part of the colonized (Arnold, 1993). The colonial power was thus defined by an inexhaustible process of negotiation, not domination.

Lahore Cantonment thus stood for much more than a strategic military station. These patterns of behaviour were attempted to be regulated by the colonial authorities through routines, sanitation, and leisure activities. Discipline became part of the routine, the usual turnover of activity, of the day, and was established as a means of production and exercise of authority. The maintenance of empire was as dependent on coercion and military force as it was on the organisation of daily experience, through the use of places, in particular the cantonment.

Economy and Controlled Urban Space

Lahore Cantonment was not economically self-sufficient. Despite its appearance as a distinct military settlement, the daily lives of the people revolved around a large civil economy of labourers, contractors, merchants, and service people. Food needed to be provided; roads repaired; their animals tended; their barracks renovated; their clothing washed; the homes serviced. The military establishment therefore relied heavily on civilian participation. This relationship did not lead to economic independence. However, economic activities in the cantonment continued to be governed by military as well as sanitary considerations and administrative control. The economy of Lahore Cantonments was therefore not a market economy but rather a regulated economy that was intended to maintain imperial order (Tan, 2005).

This economic system was based on civilian labour. In addition to the soldiers and officers, The cantonment housed a diverse workforce such as cooks, sweepers, syces, grass-cutters, washermen, water-carriers, cart-drivers, domestic servants, transport workers and petty traders (Alavi, 1995). Their labour was their daily life in the military. The presence of ‘follower lines', ‘servant quarters', ‘hospital lines', ‘syce lines', and ‘regimental bazaars' shows to what degree civilian populations had penetrated the workings of Lahore Cantonment (Ahmed, 2025). However, food preparation, animal care, transport, construction, and landscaping/stewardship were activities that drew on people who were not part of the formal military hierarchy, but were necessary to the functioning of the colonial military.

Contractors occupied a particularly important position within this economic order because they were at the intersection of civilian activities and State control. They signed contracts with the Regimental authorities, the cantonment committees and the Public Works Department to carry out their works, consequent on drainage, transport, repairs and provision of fodder (Peers, 1995). Their work connected regional business, trading and the administration of the empire. Less powerful service providers were at the lower end of the hierarchy, relying on the direct services to military households and on bazaar work. With these differences, basically, these two groups were linked on one common structure: military requirements set the tempo and guidelines of economic life (Talbot & Kamran, 2016). The cantonment economy was more than just an economy based on exchange: there was a hierarchy of economic opportunity, with access depending on serving military purposes.

This service economy helped develop new opportunities in the civilian world. Military stations generated ongoing employment and trading opportunities for commodities, which drew traders,

craftsmen and labourers to seek work (Ahmed, 2025). Roads, barracks, hospitals and drainage systems had to be maintained on an ongoing basis, and domestic workers were put to work in officers' homes. However, such opportunities were allowed only within very restricted limits of their military necessity. The civilian population engaged in economic dependency but without military status and institutional protections. This cantonment then became a 'regime of labour' with livelihoods still dependent on the jobs demanded by imperial administration (Ali, 1988; Peers, 1995).

Bazaars were a central part of this structured economy. The army was not the only place that soldiers could go to buy their daily needs, and bazaars provided food, clothes, fodder and domestic supplies, as well as a variety of personal services. Within Lahore Cantonment, both centralised and regimental bazaars emerged and played an essential role in the day-to-day lives of residents. One of the biggest and most densely populated indigenous colonies in the Cantonment was the Sadar Bazaar, which by the early twentieth century would have been home to about 5,000. Other regimental bazaars also served the specific needs of individual military units (Nathan et al., 1910). As a result, these areas were not simply add-ons to the cantonment system but were just as economically important.

Colonials, however, did not see bazaars as a normal marketplace of the town. The economic activity in these places continued to be subject to licensing, inspection, taxation, and periodic restructuring (Home, 1997). The Military Cantonments Act of 1864 provided an early framework for regulating civilian activity within military settlements, empowering military authorities to oversee sanitation, taxation, and public administration (Government of India, 1864). The revenue generated in the cantonment area was used to pay for the construction of roads, drainage systems, and public services, which were developed to serve primarily military needs. This led to administrative and financial autonomy from Lahore Municipality, which further accentuated the unique economy of the cantonment.

The Cantonments Act of 1889 was passed, which further formalized the arrangements; the Act vested more clear-cut responsibilities in Cantonment Boards, working under military supervision and Government of India control, in matters concerning public works, taxation, sanitary arrangements, and civic administration (Government of India, 1889). The economic regulation in turn became more systematic, bringing militarisation into all the activities of traders, labourers and service communities. There was an increasing reliance on administrative control over the service, which was carried out by way of licensing and inspections, rather than by military orders alone.

Sanitary concerns have often been used as the basis for the regulation of bazaars. Markets providing unhealthy markets or the "overcrowding" could either be relocated, shrunk, or rebuilt. In the 1910s, anti-malarial studies carried out at Mian Mir documented the partial demolition and reconstruction of a bazaar deemed "oversized" for the regiment it served (Arnold, 1993). This demonstrates how the movement of business activity was to be brought in line with military demands for proper health and order. The economic life could only be allowed if it did not interfere with the disciplinary setting of the military cantonment.

Even with all these interventions, the economy remained not entirely regulated. Bazaars were still lively places where exchange, interaction and negotiation took place. The soldiers met the civilians, labourers and contractors in commercial zones which were connected to the broader Lahore economy. In this regard, Lahore Cantonment was not a closed military enclave nor a typical urban neighbourhood. It was a masterfully managed urban space in which the colonial government maintained its rule over the economic life and the daily activities of these people through the control of labour, trade, and their economies.

Gender, Health, and Moral Regulation

The broader goals of colonialism influenced gender relations in Lahore Cantonment. Women did not have any marginal status in the life of the cantonment; instead, they were part of the life of the cantonment, reflecting the racial, social and moral hierarchy of the empire. European women belonged to family and domestic life and on behalf of the European colonial authority, whereas Indian women were more likely to be represented as servants, labourers, or subjects of medical and moral regulation in official discourse. In the process, this created a strongly gendered social hierarchy, with the lives of women varying widely based on their race and class.

The presence of European women within the cantonment carried symbolic importance. Officers' wives helped transform military stations from temporary encampments into permanent colonial communities. It was expected that the European household would bring discipline and stability as well as the moral superiority which British rule claimed to represent. Race exclusion and social distancing from the indigenous population were bolstered by a variety of social activities, visiting culture and domestic life in bungalow compounds (Ahmed, 2025). Respectable domesticity then was a department of colonial administration, and it was a form of imperialization in daily life.

In contrast, Indian women appeared within the cantonment under markedly different circumstances. Respectable women observing purdah remained largely absent from colonial accounts, not because they lacked social significance, but because colonial observers had limited access to their worlds, and for these women, it was not a capital rarity. Elite women engaged in social and cultural activity through gender distinct networks and private events that excluded else been included in many official narratives (Sen, 2002; Walsh, 2004). The uneven visibility of women within colonial records thus reflected the boundaries of colonial knowledge rather than the actual absence of female agency.

Women from lower social backgrounds were far more visible within cantonment life in the cantonment life. Within military households, there were several female workers who moved to and from the household as *Ayas*, as well as washerwomen and domestic servants, who were part of the wider service economy. Within military households, there were other workers, notably female, who moved between the households and the wider service economy, such as washerwomen, domestic servants and *Ayas*. These workers helped to build the residences of European officers and their families, but they were not given the same dignity as their counterparts in their own homes. The colonial house thus was a place of deference and marginalisation. Domestic order was established by Indian women's labour; it was also involved in the production of the inequalities associated with the family and race (Glover, 2008).

Regulation of prostitution, however, served to further articulate the connection between gender and colonial power. Military authorities regarded sexual behaviour as a matter of strategic concern because venereal disease threatened the health and efficiency of troops stationed throughout India. As a result, cantonments came to be significant areas where women involved in commercial sex were monitored and controlled. Official responses did not concern the sexual life of the soldier but only the control of the female body (Peers, 1998).

A significant act of legislation that enabled this control was the Contagious Diseases Act. The regulations permitted registration of women suspected of prostitution in areas that were near military establishments and allowed for medical examination of registered women (Levine, 2003). The goal stated was to decrease the occurrence of Sexually Transmitted Infections (STIs) among soldiers. But in reality, the legislation put standards of accountability in place that were not equal. Women suspected of bringing infection were subjected to compulsory exams; the male demand on which the system was based was not similarly checked (Ballhatchet, 1980).

Lock hospitals were a part of this regulation. Institutions were founded to isolate and treat women who had been diagnosed with venereal disease, and were intended to combine medicine, coercion and morality into one administrative body. Records from colonial India show an increasing

importance of lock hospitals on military stations from late in the nineteenth century (Banerjee, 2000). Their activities were part of a wider colonial policy of "medicalization" of social issues and bureaucratization of the most marginalized sub-populations.

These policies reached further than prostitution itself. Unequal mobility of women, labelling specific women's vices and association of disease with certain female bodies helped establish gendered hierarchy in cantonment society. Whereas the symbols of the women of Europe were the figures of domestic harmony and imperial authority, those of the women of India, particularly beyond the circles of elite society, were often ones of suspicion or intervention. These contrasting images upheld race differences, which were instrumental in shaping the colonial ideology.

Human health was an important motivation for the implementation of such interventions. Repeatedly, the efficiency of their armed forces was equated with the control of disease, which prompted them to increase their surveillance of spaces where health hazards may be present. They were constantly advised to increase their control over questionably healthy spaces to boost the efficiency of their armed forces, which was synonymous with disease control (Government of Punjab, 1877). The inspections done in Meean Meer Cantonment were a reflection of colonial fears about disease and disorder. Medicine thus made it acceptable for the state to encroach upon more private and intimate spheres of social activity. Women's bodies became a site for analyzing health, morality and national security concerns.

These policies should not be taken as the only expressions of medical rationality, however. Next, the selective regulation reveals the intermingled nature of gender and power in the colonial structure of governance. The examinations, confinement and surveillance had no equivalent for the group of women recognized as prostitutes whose behaviour prompted official anxiety; this anxiety was directed at soldiers whose actions were far less likely to prompt official concern (Government of India, 1889; Government of India, 1924). This led to a disproportionate burden for women in vulnerable societal roles to bear the bulk of the responsibility for maintaining military health.

Lahore Cantonment is an example of the way colonialism was realized not just by war, but also by administrative control of routine interactions. It was the same government rule in all aspects of road control, drainage and bazaar management which attempted to control sexuality, domesticity and bodily conduct. Gender emerged as one of the key elements in the reproduction and legitimation of social hierarchies within the cantonments. Colonial rule penetrated many environments of daily life, through the idealization of European domestic spaces, reliance on Indian female workers, and the compulsory regulation of prostitution. The discipline of women's bodies thus was not contained within the complacencies of the cantonment life, but was an integral part of the wider regime of imperial order in Punjab.

Leisure and Social Boundaries

Within the social life of Lahore Cantonment, leisure had an important position but on the other hand the spaces used for leisure activities were not politically neutral, nor socially inclusive. Clubs, race courses, sports grounds, and entertainment venues provided the contexts for asserting and reinforcing colonial hierarchies and racial differences. With control over social interaction and leisure, British authorities wanted to maintain what they saw as the social gulf that imperialism required. Recreational institutions thus helped to sustain boundaries between ruler and subject, which served to uphold colonial order.

European clubs represented the clearest expression of these divisions. Clubs were formed to give the colonists some social and cultural comfort in an unfamiliar world; they provided a place to eat, read, dance, and socialize amongst the colonial elite (Ahmed, 2025). The admission procedure, membership dues and social rules of admitted persons kept most of the Indians outside. Although some exceptions had been made for a select few Indian elites, there was a limitation on inclusion, and it was carefully monitored. These institutions had an exclusiveness about them that

reinforced the idea that there was a Western ruling population that differed from the ruled population and that it was partially based on this separation.

The significance of clubs extended beyond recreation. There were informal linkages that helped consolidate the ties between the administration and reaffirm the imperial identities. Community within these areas helped to create a feeling of belonging for military officers, civil servants, and their families (King, 1984). The club thus served as an enterprise of colonial unity and allowed boundaries to be crossed between leisure and authority.

Race courses also mirrored the social subdivision of life in the cantonments. The game of horse racing was a big part of the recreational activities of the British people in India, and military and civil elite officials participated in it (Huggins, 2004). In addition to entertainment, race meetings were a platform for demonstrating status and prestige. Participation, hospitality and seating arrangements often reflected overall racialized and social/agency structures (Huggins, 2004; Mangan, 1986). Elites from India occasionally came along, but they did not generally interfere with the overwhelmingly closed nature of these institutions. The race course then came to represent imperial confidence and the disparity of privilege in the colonial society.

Sport played an important role in shaping cantonment culture. A lifestyle of organized sports, from cricket to polo, hockey, tennis, and other such exercises, was encouraged as a good habit for physical health, discipline and morals (Mangan, 1986). Sport helped to instil notions of manhood closely linked to service to the Empire, with an emphasis on endurance, self-control, and teamwork. This was complemented by recreational pursuits with the emphasis on developing qualities that were considered to be desirable in soldiers in the colonial army.

Yet access to sporting spaces remained unequal. There were more opportunities for European soldiers to take part in organised recreation, and recreational facilities were reflective of official investment in soldiers' welfare. In addition to sports, Indian soldiers participated in such activities, especially as the military authorities began seeing the significance of it in terms of morale and fitness (Roy, 2013). However, the racial divisions present elsewhere in cantonment society were often reproduced within recreational spaces. Opportunities for truly shared leisure experiences were restricted by separate facilities, through participation differentiated forms (whether planned or implicit) and by informal barriers.

The organisation of leisure within Lahore Cantonment reveals that recreation itself formed part of the broader architecture of colonial rule. Relaxation areas were also places of social differentiation. Sociability was limited in clubs, sport courses were marked by hierarchy, and sporting institutions reinforced notions based on race, class and authority. Leisure, then, was involved in upholding the imperial frontier, helping to normalise exclusion in familiar spaces (Talbot & Kamran, 2016).

Meanwhile, at the same time, these borders were never firmly established. However, there were some opportunities for exclusive area exchanges as well as some places for social exchanges, associated with sports activities and public celebrations, by Indian elites occasionally. There are moments when we are reminded that colonial society was not entirely divided but was still dynamic and contested. However, even the continued use of racially exclusive recreational institutions makes this point evident, because imperial power depended in large part on maintaining differences between its rulers and its ruled. So leisure in Lahore Cantonment was far more than just entertainment; it was a place for the construction, public display and defence of colonial identities.

Conclusion

Lahore Cantonment brings the reality of colonial rule in Punjab to the fore, covering multiple areas beyond military conquest and administrative reform. Although coercive power remained essential to the maintenance of empire, but so was the organisation of everyday life in Britain. The cantonment developed into a highly controlled society where social relations and economic

activities, as well as health and recreational walks, were organized using imperial priorities. These various dimensions explore the manner in which colonial power operated, not only through acts of force, but also through everyday, routine practices of those who came under its control and lived within military settlements.

The findings of this research reveal that Lahore Cantonment was a miniature mirror image of colonial governance in Punjab. Social structures excluded European officers, and yet, taken for granted, Indian soldiers and civilian labourers were essential to their service. Racial segregation facilitated interactions among different communities, and racial differences were integrated into the spatial landscape of the cantonment. Economic regulation provided for the existence of bazaars, contractors, and labourers to serve military interests while maintaining them under administrative supervision. Health policies and moral interventions were able to create an extension of the state in intimate life, mainly with regard to sexuality and the surveillance of women's bodies. Imperial identities were also reinforced through the taking up of social boundaries in 'leisure' spaces.

Taken together, these practices suggest that colonial rule depended on the production of order rather than its simple enforcement. The cantonment served, in a sense, to re-normalise discipline, to make hierarchy visible and to establish difference in the institutional order. The rule on housing, employment, sanitation and sociability, with which people repeatedly confronted the imperial power, became part of the common flow of daily life. Finally, colonial governance accounted for its effectiveness no longer just in terms of military strength but by its ability to structure social relations in an apparently natural and predictable manner.

At the same time Lahore Cantonment brings out in relief the paradoxes of British rule in Punjab. The colonial state relied upon Indian soldiers for the protection of its imperial interests but failed to grant them equality in the military. It was based on civilian manpower and native trade and attempts were made to curb and control the population supporting these. It instilled ideas of health and morality, and instituted policies that disproportionately affected the vulnerable populations of women. The cantonment thus shows the conflicts felt between dependence and exclusion that were part of the broader colonial experience.

The idea of using Lahore Cantonment as a lens onto everyday life reveals that it was more of a perception of lived reality rather than an elite decision-making or a battle narrative. This "on-the-ground" view broadens our understanding of colonial Punjab, demonstrating that power was enacted not just in formal institutional structures, but through daily activities too. Thus, the study of cantonment society cannot only be comprehended as a part of military history but also lies in the wider sphere of social and city history of South Asia. Lahore Cantonment, in fact, shows that the survival of British rule in the Punjab depended upon the constant negotiation and recreation of British order in the spaces of the lived day-to-day procedures. Understanding these processes allows us to recognize the cantonment not simply as a military installation, but as a significant site through which empire was experienced, contested, and sustained.

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